

LAYER 1 OF 13

FRONTEND FOUNDATIONS

What Your Users See and Touch

TIER 1 — SOLOPRENEUR

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Part of the Builder Certification Series

What This Kit Covers

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This kit covers Layer 1: Frontend Foundations—what your users see and touch. The frontend is your app's screens, buttons, menus, and forms. It's the thing people pull up on their phone or open on their laptop. When someone says "the app," they're talking about this.

You're not going to write code by hand. You're going to describe what you want to an AI coding tool—something like Cursor, Lovable, Bolt, or Claude Code—and let it build the screens for you. Your job is to know what to ask for, check that it works, and fix what doesn't. That's what this certification proves you can do.

This kit walks you through three levels of mastery. Tier 1 is for someone shipping their first app. Tier 2 is for someone whose app is growing and needs to stay organized. Tier 3 is for someone running a platform that multiple teams build on. Start at Tier 1. You can always come back for the rest.

Why It Matters

If your app looks broken on someone's phone, they won't use it. Period. They won't complain—they'll just close it and never come back. The frontend is the first thing people judge, and first impressions are permanent.

Here's the thing about AI coding tools: they're excellent at building things that look great on your laptop screen. But they consistently skip things you didn't ask for—like making sure the layout works on a phone, or making sure someone can navigate your app with a keyboard. AI builds exactly what you describe. If you don't know what to ask for, you get gaps. This kit teaches you what to ask for.

Certification Tier Map

There are three certification tiers. Each one builds on the one before it. Here's a quick look at who each tier is for and what you'll prove you can do.

Tier

Who It's For

What You Prove

Tier 1

Solo builders shipping their first app

You can describe what you want to AI, check that it built it right, and ship an app that works on a phone.

Tier 2

Growing teams and apps that need to stay organized

You can keep your app consistent as it grows—same look, same patterns, good performance—even when multiple people or AI tools are building parts of it.

Tier 3

Platforms with multiple teams and compliance requirements

You can run a frontend operation at scale—multiple teams, accessibility compliance, multiple brands, automated quality checks.

TIER 1 CERTIFICATION GOAL

You can describe what you want your app to look like, use an AI coding tool to build it, check the result on a phone and a computer, and ship something your users can actually use.

What You Need to Know

You don't need to memorize code. You need to understand a handful of concepts so you can describe what you want clearly and catch problems in what AI gives you back.

How apps are organized: Modern apps are built from components—reusable pieces like a header, a card, a form, a button. Think of them like LEGO blocks. You need to know this so you can tell AI “build me a job card component” instead of “build me the whole page,” which gives you something harder to fix.

How layouts work on different screens: Your AI tool uses something called responsive design to make your app look right on phones, tablets, and desktops. If you don't check the phone version, you'll ship something that only works on the screen you built it on.

How styling stays consistent: AI uses a styling system (usually Tailwind CSS) to apply colors, spacing, and fonts. You don't need to learn Tailwind—but if your app's buttons are three different sizes on three different pages, that's a styling consistency problem you need to catch.

How to check that everyone can use your app: Accessibility means people with disabilities can use your app—screen readers work, buttons are reachable by keyboard, text has enough contrast. AI almost never adds this on its own. You have to ask for it.

The vibecoder workflow: Describe what you want → AI builds it → you check the output on a real phone → you tell AI what to fix → repeat until it's right → ship it. This is the loop. Every exam question tests whether you can run this loop effectively.

Your Toolkit

Your AI coding tool is the center of your workflow. Everything else supports it.

AI coding tool (pick one): Cursor, Lovable, Bolt, Claude Code, Windsurf, or whatever AI-assisted builder you prefer. This is where you'll describe what you want and iterate on the output.

A framework (AI picks this for you): Your AI will likely use Next.js or SvelteKit to build your app. You don't need to choose—just know that it's the engine underneath the screens AI generates.

A browser for testing: Chrome DevTools lets you preview your app on different screen sizes without needing every device. Right-click → Inspect → toggle the device toolbar.

Certification Exam Topics

Every exam question is scenario-based. You'll see a situation and need to identify what's right, what's wrong, or what to do next. Here's what gets tested:

App organization: Can you tell whether AI built your app in a clean, organized way—or dumped everything into one messy folder?

Phone and tablet layouts: Can you spot when your app looks right on a laptop but falls apart on a phone screen?

Accessibility basics: Can you identify when AI skipped things like alt text on images, keyboard navigation, or proper heading structure?

Styling consistency: Can you tell when your app's buttons, colors, and spacing are inconsistent across different screens?

Where code runs: Do you understand the basics of why some parts of your app run on a server and some in the browser—and why it matters for speed?

Image loading: Can you check that images load efficiently instead of slowing down your entire app?

Forms that work: Can you evaluate whether a form handles mistakes gracefully—showing clear errors, not losing what the user typed?

Your AI workflow: Can you describe a component clearly, give AI useful feedback when the output is wrong, and iterate to a working result?

Common Pitfalls

These are the mistakes vibecoders make most often at this layer. No judgment—they're easy to make. But if you recognize any of them in your own workflow, fix them before sitting for the exam.

Never checking your app on an actual phone. It looks fine on your laptop. It's broken on mobile. Every time.

Asking AI to "build the whole page" instead of building it from smaller pieces. Big prompts produce big messes.

Not setting up a folder structure before you start generating. AI will put files wherever it wants—and six weeks later, nobody can find anything.

Skipping accessibility because AI doesn't add it unless you ask. Screen readers, keyboard navigation, alt text—none of it shows up automatically.

Treating AI's first output as final. It's a first draft. Always review. Always iterate.

Letting every page look slightly different because you never defined your brand rules (colors, fonts, spacing) in one place.

Tier 1 Self-Assessment Checklist

Before you take the exam, run through these questions. Every "no" is something to work on.

Can you describe a screen or feature to AI clearly enough that you get something usable on the first or second try?

Have you actually opened your app on a phone (not just a laptop simulator) and confirmed it works?

Can a user navigate your app using only a keyboard—no mouse required?

Did you set up a consistent folder structure and naming convention before you started generating?

If someone else looked at your app, would every page feel like it belongs to the same product?

Have you tested your forms with empty submissions, weird characters, and very long text?

Do you know how to open browser DevTools and check if your app is throwing errors?

AI Audit Prompt Template

Copy this prompt into your AI coding tool to get a quick health check on your frontend. It checks the same things the certification exam covers.

Review my app's frontend and check the following. For each one, tell me pass or fail with a specific example:

Organization: Are my components cleanly separated into their own files with consistent naming?

Mobile: Does every screen look correct at phone size (375px wide)?

Accessibility: Does the HTML use the right elements (buttons for actions, links for navigation)? Are images labeled? Can I tab through the whole app?

Consistency: Are colors, fonts, button sizes, and spacing the same everywhere?

Speed: Are images optimized? Is the app loading code it doesn't need yet?

Forms: Do forms show clear error messages and keep user input on failed submissions?

Give me an overall score out of 6 and list the top 3 things to fix first.

What's Next

Once you've gone through this kit and can answer "yes" to the self-assessment checklist, you're ready for the Layer 1 certification exam at your target tier.

The best way to prepare: build something real. Pick a project—even a small one—and go through the full loop. Describe it to AI. Check what it builds.

Fix the gaps. Ship it. Pay attention to every place you catch a mistake.

Those catches are exactly what the exam tests.

CERTIFICATION PATHWAY

Associate Builder: Pass all 13 layers at Tier 1

Certified Builder: Pass all 13 layers at Tier 1 + Tier 2

MADE Certified: Pass all 39 tier exams + capstone project

Each exam requires 80% to pass. You can retake after a 24-hour cooldown. No rush—take the time to build something real first.

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